



ACTION, REACTION
Far left, smoke rises from a Tehran building after an Israeli airstrike, Jun. 16; left, a building in Tel Aviv hit by an Iranian missile, Jun. 22

AFP

EXPERTS ARE CALLING THIS A PAUSE, NOT PEACE, AS NONE OF THE FUNDAMENTAL ISSUES, LIKE IRAN'S NUCLEAR PROWESS THAT LED TO THE 12-DAY WAR, HAVE BEEN ADEQUATELY ADDRESSED

phant Netanyahu asserted, "For decades, I have promised you that Iran would not have nuclear weapons. And, indeed, in all of the swift actions that our soldiers carried out, we sent Iran's nuclear project to oblivion."

On its part, Iran declared that it had retaliated by targeting America's Al Udeid air base in Qatar with the exact number of missiles that the US used to strike its nuclear facilities. It is widely believed that Tehran had warned the American forces of the attack beforehand, enabling them to avoid military casualties. Iran maintained that it had given a befitting reply to both American and Israeli military adventurism and despite the strikes, its nuclear capability wasn't dented. In a post on X, Iran's supreme leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei wrote, "Those who know the Iranian people and their history know that the Iranian nation isn't a nation that surrenders."

Not Quite the Hammer

Despite Trump claiming Op Midnight Hammer to be an unqualified success, mainstream US media, including the *New York Times* and the CNN, quoting leaked US intelligence assessments, reported that American military strikes on Iran's three nuclear facilities did not destroy the core components of the country's nuclear programme, but only set it back by months rather than years. Also, that Iran's stockpile of enriched uranium had been moved out of the sites prior to the US strikes. The damage at Fordow, Natanz and Isfahan, it is claimed, may have been largely restricted to overground structures, including their power infrastructure and some facilities used to turn uranium into metal for bomb-making.

Former Indian Army chief General Manoj Mukund Naravane believes such analysis means the bunker bombs may not have caused the massive destruction that Trump had hoped for. With his biggest military asset possibly falling short, the American president, Naravane reckons, pushed for truce so that he could work out other strategies to attack Iran. "The truce will then only be temporary," Naravane says. "It seems more like Iran, Israel and the US agreed to it because they wanted time to assess the outcomes of the war, their strengths and weaknesses, regroup their military forces and resources and then possibly go at each other's throat again."

There are other major discomforting implications for the US and Israel, especially the fact that their combined strikes failed to destroy an estimate 400 kg of Iran's highly enriched stockpile. Dr Anil Kakodkar, former chairman of India's Atomic Energy Commission, says that if reports that Iran had moved out its stock of enriched uranium before the attack are true, then Tehran retains the capability to assemble crude atomic devices that could be quite potent. "Iran has the capability to quickly rebuild its centrifuges," he says. "So, all the US and Israel may have done is to have postponed the development.